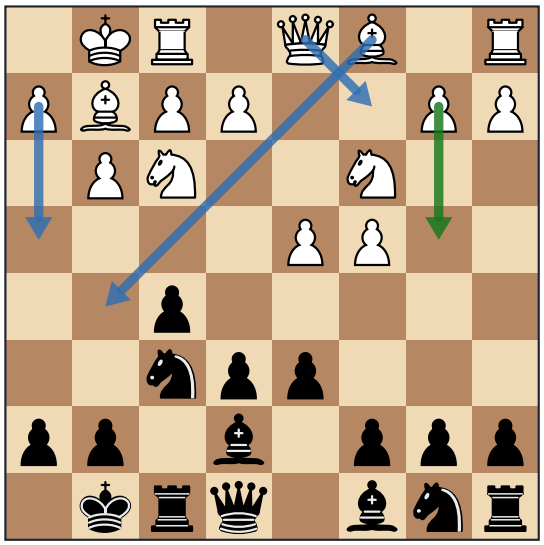
Dutch Defense

ECO A80-A99 | 69 named lines | Dutch family

In one sentence: A fighting defense that claims e4 immediately and aims for kingside attacks, with a wide choice of structures.

Memory pattern: f5 controls e4: then Nf6, e6 or g6 and a kingside attack.



Main line: 1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 Qe8

Key ideas

1. Control e4 with ...f5 and develop the knight to f6.
2. Stonewall: pawns on f5/e6/d5 with an outpost on e4.
3. Leningrad: ...g6, ...Bg7 and a kingside pawn break with ...e5.
4. Classical: ...d6, ...Be7 and flexible play.
5. Watch the e1-h4 diagonal and the weak e6 square.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.76** (clearly better for White, depth 17). Best: b4.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black fights for e4 with ...f5: Stonewall (f5/e6/d5), Leningrad (g6/Bg7/d6) or Classical (d6/Be7).
2. Where does my king go?	Castle short, but the e1-h4 diagonal and the e6 square need care.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Ne4 outpost, Bd6, Qe8-h5. White: Bg5/Bf4, Nc3, e3/e4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black attacks the kingside with ...Ne4 and ...f4; White uses the weak e6 square and queenside play.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants to exploit the weakened king and e6; Black wants a kingside attack and control of e4.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 Qe8

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... f5	Control e4. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2. c4	Space. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
3. g3	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
3... e6	Stonewall base. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4. Bg2	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
4... Be7	Develops the bishop to e7.
5. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
5... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6. O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6... d6	Leningrad center. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
7. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
7... Qe8	Prepare ...Qh5. Queen move: puts pressure on a target (watch for tempo-gaining attacks).



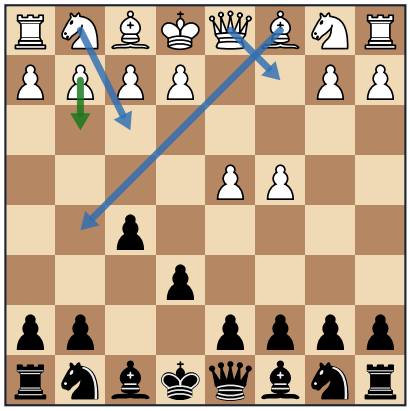
After 1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6



After Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

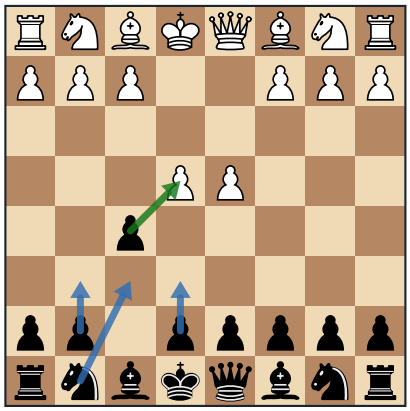


Position after the line

Classical Variation A84 | 13 lines

`1.d4 f5 2.c4 e6`

Stockfish: **+0.56** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: g3.
What to look for: d4 (center); c4 (space); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Ilyin-Zhenevsky Variation, Blackburne Attack, Buenos Aires Variation, Huisl Variation

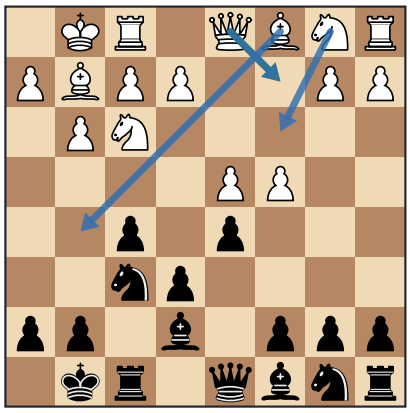


Position after the line

Staunton Gambit A82 | 8 lines

`1.d4 f5 2.e4`

Stockfish: **+0.21** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: fxe4.
What to look for: f5 (control e4); Nf6 (develop); e6 (Stonewall base)
Sub-variations: American Attack, Tartakower Variation, Alekhine Variation, Chigorin Variation



Position after the line

Stonewall Variation A92 | 7 lines

`1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d5`

Stockfish: **+0.58** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: Qc2.
What to look for: d4 (center); c4 (space); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Modern Variation, Botvinnik Variation, Chekhover Variation

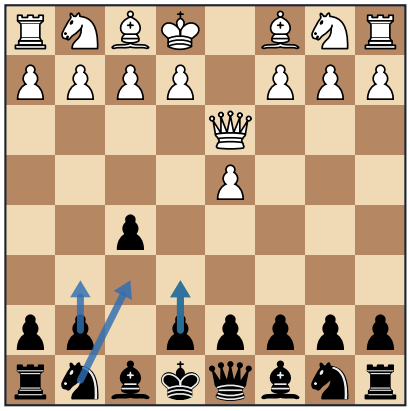


Position after the line

Leningrad Variation A86 | 5 lines

`1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 g6`

Stockfish: **+0.60** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: Bg2.
What to look for: d4 (center); c4 (space); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Carlsbad Variation, Warsaw Variation, Matulovic Variation

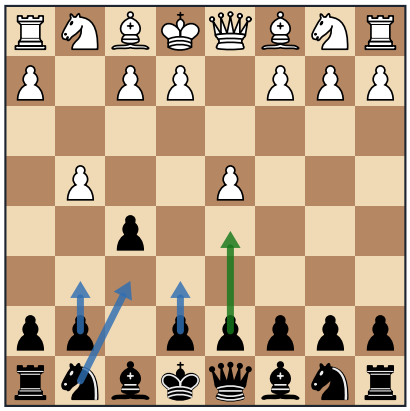


Position after the line

Manhattan Gambit A80 | 4 lines

`1.d4 f5 2.Qd3`

Stockfish: **+0.28** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: e6.
What to look for: f5 (control e4); Nf6 (develop); e6 (Stonewall base)
Sub-variations: Anti-Classical Line, Anti-Leningrad, Anti-Modern, Anti-Stonewall



Position after the line

Krejcik Gambit A80 | 2 lines

`1.d4 f5 2.g4`

Stockfish: **-0.04** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: f5 (control e4); Nf6 (develop); e6 (Stonewall base)
Sub-variations: Tate Gambit

Detailed repertoire notes

Dutch Defense (Leningrad / Stonewall) (A80-A99, Black)

```
1.d4 f5 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.O-O O-O 6.c4 d6 7.Nc3 Qe8 8.d5 Na6 9.Rb1 Nc5 10.Nd4 a5 11.b3 Bd7
```

Idea: Control e4, build a kingside attack, and choose between a Leningrad or Stonewall structure.

Structure: Leningrad: ...f5/...d6/...g6 with Bg7 for kingside play. Stonewall: pawns on f5/e6/d5 with an outpost on e4.

Pieces: Bg7 (Leningrad) or Ne4 with a bishop on d6 (Stonewall), queen e8-h5, rooks f8/e8.

Plan: Complete the setup, then ...e5 (Leningrad) or ...Ne4 and ...Bd6 (Stonewall) with kingside attack.

King: Castle early; watch the h4-e1 diagonal and e6. **Opponent:** Bg5, Nc3-b5, h4 and e4; take advantage of the e1-h4 diagonal.

Watch out: The e1-h4 diagonal and e6 weaknesses need care; White's Bf4 and Ne5 can be annoying.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Choose your setup (Stonewall or Leningrad) and learn its plans. Be ready for White's Bg5, g3/Bg2 fianchetto and e4 break.

Why play it

A fighting defense that claims e4 immediately and aims for kingside attacks, with a wide choice of structures.

Typical mistakes

- Ignoring Bg5 and h4 attacks on the king.
- Playing ...d5 too early in the Leningrad and losing the e4 outpost.
- Allowing Nc3-b5 hits on c7.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bg5 and Nc3-b5-c7 forks when Black plays slowly.
- Staunton Gambit (e4) tactics if Black grabs pawns without care.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Complex middlegames; Black's king safety is the main issue.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Dutch Defense (all lines)** — A80
  `1.d4 f5`
  - **Alapin Variation** — A80
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.Qd3`
  - **Fianchetto Attack** — A81
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.g3`
  - **Hopton Attack** — A80
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.Bg5`
  - **Korchnoi Attack** — A80
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.h3`
  - **Krejcik Gambit** — A80
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.g4`
    - **Tate Gambit** — A80
      `1.d4 f5 2.g4 -> 2...fxg4 3.e4 d5 4.Nc3`
  - **Manhattan Gambit** — A80
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.Qd3`
    - **Anti-Classical Line** — A80
      `1.d4 f5 2.Qd3 -> 2...e6 3.g4`
    - **Anti-Leningrad** — A80
      `1.d4 f5 2.Qd3 -> 2...g6 3.g4`
    - **Anti-Modern** — A80
      `1.d4 f5 2.Qd3 -> 2...d6 3.g4`
    - **Anti-Stonewall** — A80
      `1.d4 f5 2.Qd3 -> 2...d5 3.g4`
  - **Raphael Variation** — A80
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.Nc3`
  - **Staunton Gambit** — A82
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.e4`
    - **American Attack** — A82
      `1.d4 f5 2.e4 -> 2...fxe4 3.Nd2`
    - **Tartakower Variation** — A82
      `1.d4 f5 2.e4 -> 2...fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.g4`
    - **Chigorin Variation** — A83
      `1.d4 f5 2.e4 -> 2...fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 c6`
    - **Nimzowitsch Variation** — A83
      `1.d4 f5 2.e4 -> 2...fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 b6`
    - **Alekhine Variation** — A83
      `1.d4 f5 2.e4 -> 2...fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 g6 5.h4`
    - **Lasker Variation** — A83
      `1.d4 f5 2.e4 -> 2...fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 g6 5.f3`
  - **Classical Variation** — A84
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 e6`
    - **Blackburne Attack** — A91
      `1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nh3`
    - **Buenos Aires Variation** — A96
      `1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 a5`
    - **Huisl Variation** — A96
      `1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 Ne4`
    - **Ilyin-Zhenevsky Variation** — A97
      `1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 Qe8`
      - **Alatortsev-Lisitsyn Line** — A98
        `1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 Qe8 -> 8.Qc2`
      - **Modern Main Line** — A99
        `1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 Qe8 -> 8.b3`
      - **Winter Variation** — A97
        `1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d6 7.Nc3 Qe8 -> 8.Re1`
  - **Hevendehl Gambit** — A80
    `1.d4 f5 -> 2.g4 e5`

- **Normal Variation** A84
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6
- **Omega-Isis Gambit** A80
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.Nf3 e5
- **Staunton Gambit Accepted** A82
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.e4 fxe4
- **Barcza Variation** A80
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.c3
- **Bellon Gambit** A84
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 e6 3.e4
- **Fianchetto Variation** A86
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3
- **Janzen-Korchnoi Gambit** A80
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.h3 Nf6 3.g4
- **Kingfisher Gambit** A80
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4
- **Queen's Knight Variation** A85
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.Nc3
- **Rubinstein Variation** A84
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3
- **Senechaud Gambit** A80
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.Bf4 e6 3.g4
- **Spielmann Gambit** A80
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.g4
- **Bladel Variation** A84
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Nh6
- **Leningrad Variation** A86
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 g6
  - **Carlsbad Variation** A81
    1.d4 f5 2.g3 g6 3.Bg2 Bg7 4.Nh3
  - **Matulovic Variation** A89
    1.d4 f5 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.O-O O-O 6.c4 d6 7.Nc3 Nc6
  - **Warsaw Variation** A88
    1.d4 f5 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.O-O O-O 6.c4 d6 7.Nc3 c6
- **Semi-Leningrad Variation** A81
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 g6
- **Blackburne Variation** A81
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 e6 4.Nh3
- **Blackmar's Second Gambit** A82
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.e4 fxe4 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.f3
- **Krause Variation** A84
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3 Nc6
- **Nimzo-Dutch Variation** A90
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Bb4
  - **Alekhine Variation** A90
    1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Bb4 -> 5.Bd2 Be7
- **Hort-Antoshin System** A86
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 d6 4.Bg2 c6 5.Nc3 Qc7
- **Leningrad** A81
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.g3 c6 3.Bg2 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.O-O Nh6
  - **Basman System** A81
    1.d4 f5 2.g3 c6 3.Bg2 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.O-O Nh6
- **Alekhine Variation** A92
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O Ne4
- **Stonewall Variation** A92
  1.d4 f5 -> 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d5
  - **Modern Variation** A90
    1.d4 f5 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.g3 c6 5.Bg2 d5 6.O-O Bd6
  - **Botvinnik Variation** A93
    1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d5 -> 7.b3
  - **Chekhover Variation** A95
    1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.O-O d5 -> 7.Nc3 c6 8.Qc2 Qe8 9.Bg5

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 f5 2.c4 Nf6 3.g3 e6 4.Bg2 Be7 5.Nf3 0-0
```

Plan chain

White	d4 -> c4 -> Nf3 -> g3 -> Bg2
Black	f5 -> Nf6 -> e6 -> g6 -> Bg7

Three rules to remember

1. f5 controls e4: then Nf6, e6 or g6 and a kingside attack.
2. Black attacks the kingside with ...Ne4 and ...f4; White uses the weak e6 square and queenside play.
3. White wants to exploit the weakened king and e6; Black wants a kingside attack and control of e4.

Pawn structure in one line

Black fights for e4 with ...f5: Stonewall (f5/e6/d5), Leningrad (g6/Bg7/d6) or Classical (d6/Be7).